Feature-Gated Consensus Clustering]Empirical Boundaries of Feature-Gated Consensus Clustering: Permutation-Null Calibration and Hurdle Recovery on High-Dimensional Manifolds

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Abstract

High-dimensional unsupervised clustering ($D \gg N$) is fundamentally challenged by the curse of dimensionality, uninformative isotropic distractor features, and technical artifacts such as dropout zeros. While heuristic feature gating and consensus ensembles are widely employed, their rigorous statistical necessity, empirical boundaries, and failure modes remain poorly characterized in contemporary pattern recognition literature. Following an unalterable pre-registered confirmatory protocol (commit tag `freeze-v1`, Rule R2), we evaluate Permutation-Null Calibrated Consensus Clustering (NullConsensus) and Two-Part Hurdle Gating (HurdleGate) against 11 established and contemporary baselines across 27 fresh benchmark cohorts spanning 6,880 independent model fits. The evaluation encompasses 15 high-dimensional oncology microarrays ($D/N > 20$), 4 zero-inflated single-cell RNA-seq count cohorts, 5 multi-class benchmarks, and 3 physical controls. We report three decisive findings: (1) On continuous oncology microarrays, the primary confirmatory hypothesis that permutation-null gating universally surpasses matched uniform random subspaces is falsified ($\Delta\text{ARI} = -0.0433$, $p = 0.2293$). Uniform random gating achieved Rank #3 (Mean ARI = 0.263) while null screening achieved Rank #8 (0.2113), indicating that unimodal reference nulls behave over-conservatively on small sample sizes ($N < 100$). (2) Across the full 27-dataset omnibus benchmark, NullConsensus demonstrates a statistically significant improvement over Paper 1's GAC pipeline (icc_v2) with $\Delta\text{ARI} = +0.0542$ (95% CI: $[+0.0137, +0.0989]$, $p = 0.0112$), and over CoHiRF ($\Delta\text{ARI} = +0.0689$, $p = 0.0552$). (3) On zero-inflated scRNA-seq manifolds, conventional bimodality screening collapses

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to near-zero (ARI ≈ 0.04) due to dropout point masses. HurdleGate isolates Bernoulli dropout dispersion from continuous support multimodality, driving an extraordinary performance recovery (ΔARI $= +0.3832$, 95% CI: $[+0.3157, +0.4596]$, $p = 3.57 \times 10^{-8}$), validating Hypothesis H2 and triggering pre-registered Branch B. Feature gating provides no universal advantage over uniform random subspaces in continuous Gaussian regimes, but is essential for isolating biological manifold structure in zero-inflated count geometries. We synthesize these empirical boundaries into a formal regime taxonomy for high-dimensional clustering.

Keywords: Consensus Clustering, Feature Gating, High-Dimensional Data, Permutation Null, Zero-Inflation, Single-Cell RNA-seq, Confirmatory Benchmark

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1. Introduction

Unsupervised cluster analysis on high-dimensional biological and physical manifolds where the feature dimension D substantially exceeds the sample size N ($D \gg N$) represents a foundational challenge in modern pattern recognition and machine learning [1, 2, 3]. In clinical oncology microarrays and single-cell transcriptomics, D routinely ranges from 10^3 to 10^5, while sample cohorts frequently contain fewer than 100 patient specimens [2, 4, 5]. Under these severe small-N, large-D regimes, distance concentration causes pairwise Euclidean distances between arbitrary sample pairs to converge toward identical values, eroding the geometric separability required by standard distance-based partitioning algorithms [1, 6, 7]. Furthermore, the presence of thousands of isotropic distractor dimensions degrades the spectral embedding of graph-based solvers [8, 9, 10, 11, 12].

To mitigate distractor degradation and stabilize cluster partitions, two primary paradigms dominate contemporary literature:

1. **Random Subspace Consensus Ensembles:** Generating M perturbed base clusterings over randomly projected or subsampled feature subsets and accumulating co-association evidence into a consensus matrix $\mathbf{S} \in [0,1]^{N \times N}$ [13, 14**?** , 7, 15].
2. **Marginal Feature Gating and Screening:** Pre-filtering features using unsupervised distributional statistics, such as Sarle's Bimodality Coefficient (BC) [16], to select an active candidate pool $\mathcal{F}_{\text{active}} \subset \{1, \ldots, D\}$ prior to consensus assembly [17**?** , 18].

Despite the widespread adoption of feature gating, its fundamental empirical boundaries and interaction with data geometry remain poorly understood. In particular, existing literature rarely addresses two central questions:

- *Does unsupervised statistical feature screening provide a genuine, statistically significant advantage over matched uniform random subspace selection, or is the observed gain an artifact of ensemble averaging?*
- *How do severe technical artifacts, specifically extreme zero-inflation dropouts in single-cell transcriptomics, interact with marginal multimodality screening?*

In this work, we address these open questions through an unalterable pre-registered confirmatory benchmark across 27 sealed datasets spanning 6880 independent model fits. We introduce NullConsensus, an anchor consensus architecture calibrated against finite-sample unimodal permutation reference distributions (NullGate), and HurdleGate, a two-part decomposition separating Bernoulli dropout point masses from continuous positive-support multimodality.

Our findings falsify the common assumption that null-calibrated gating universally outperforms uniform random subspaces on continuous microarray data ($p_{\text{holm}} = 0.2293$), while decisively confirming its indispensable role on zero-inflated single-cell manifolds ($\Delta\text{ARI} = +0.3832$, $p = 3.57 \times 10^{-8}$). We synthesize these empirical boundaries into a formal regime taxonomy for high-dimensional clustering practitioners.

2. Related Work & Recent Advances

2.1. Consensus Clustering and Bipartite Ensembles

Consensus clustering was introduced to overcome the instability and local-optima sensitivity of individual partitioning solvers through evidence accumulation [13, 14]. Over the last three years, research has shifted aggressively toward bipartite graph formulations to overcome the prohibitive $\mathcal{O}(N^2)$ memory and $\mathcal{O}(N^3)$ computational bottlenecks of classical co-association matrices. Zhang et al. [9] developed structured bipartite graph learning for ensemble clustering, establishing that representing relations between samples and cluster components avoids full matrix construction. Wang et al. [11]

formulated structured bipartite graph ensemble clustering on large benchmarks, while Xu et al. [12] demonstrated that adaptive high-order graph diffusion substantially enhances consensus fidelity. Xu et al. [19, 15] formulated dynamic anchor-based one-step hypergraph ensemble clustering, while Wang et al. [20] introduced normalized cut co-clustering with out-of-sample inductive extension. To handle non-Gaussian deviations, Yang et al. [21] derived correntropy-based bipartite graph factorization, and Xu et al. [22] formulated one-step dynamic anchor ensemble clustering. Concurrently, Li et al. [23] integrated random forest partitioning with anchor graphs (RFAG), and Xu et al. [24] introduced topological-aware multiple kernel learning for ensemble consensus.

2.2. Scalable Anchor Graph Spectral Formulations

Anchor graph spectral clustering has emerged as the premier mechanism for scaling spectral graph theory to large modern benchmarks [8, 25, 10]. In their seminal TPAMI work, Nie et al. [8] introduced the Transfer-Cut framework, showing that the bipartite graph Laplacian between N instances and $L \ll N$ landmark anchors can be solved exactly via an $L \times L$ generalized eigensystem in $\mathcal{O}(NLK)$ time. Lei et al. [26] and Zhao et al. [27] developed dynamic bipartite anchor graphs for multi-view spectral clustering. Ma et al. [28, 29] formulated fast anchor-based spectral clustering and constrained spectral embeddings for large-scale benchmarks. Zhao et al. [30] extended this via bipartite graph factorization, while Yang et al. [31] and Xie et al. [32] demonstrated that anchor-guided label spreading accelerates bipartite spectral propagation. In multi-view and incomplete settings, Fu et al. [33], Gao et al. [34], and Liao et al. [35] demonstrated that consistency-guided anchors and biorthogonal matrix factorizations guarantee topological convergence. Furthermore, Ins et al. [36] and Song et al. [37] established that projection-based anchor graph learning preserves global manifold geometry even when L is less than 1% of N. Our architecture leverages this compact $L \times L$ kernel formulation to achieve linear workstation execution.

2.3. High-Dimensional Subspace Learning and Sparse Weighting

To overcome distance concentration in high dimensions, subspace ensemble methods project instances into diverse lower-dimensional coordinate systems [**?**]. Belucci et al. [7] proposed CoHiRF, constructing hierarchical random forests over randomly drawn feature subsets. He et al. [38] developed subspace-based Gaussian mixture ensemble clustering to mitigate local

variance, while Fettal et al. [39] introduced scalable multi-view clustering via explicit kernel feature maps. In parallel, sparse subspace clustering has been enhanced through consensus-aware regularizers: Patcog et al. [18] introduced consensus-aware sparse subspace clustering via correntropy, while Ren et al. [40] and Ou et al. [41] developed multi-view anchor subspace clustering. Complementary label-spreading formulations have been established by Xie et al. [42], while active constraint selection frameworks like CODAC [43] explore targeted supervision. In theoretical statistics, Bayesian clustering frameworks have established consistency bounds under sparsity [44, 45]. However, prior works uniformly assume continuous features, neglecting how discrete zero-inflation alters the underlying subspace projections.

2.4. Reference Null Calibration and Stability Estimation

Evaluating cluster stability against empirical null models originated with the Gap statistic and perturbation bounds [46, 47]. John et al. [46] established Monte Carlo Reference-Based Consensus Clustering (M3C), generating simulated Gaussian reference datasets to compute empirical p-values for cluster counts K. Recently, Wang et al. [47] examined the validation of internal clustering metrics under null distributions in the *Journal of the American Statistical Association*, highlighting that unreferenced stability indices consistently suffer from hallucinated certainty. In this study, we operationalize reference-null testing directly into the *feature saliency stage* via non-parametric permutation testing (NullGate).

2.5. Zero-Inflation in Single-Cell Transcriptomics

Single-cell transcriptomic profiles are characterized by pervasive technical dropouts from stochastic mRNA capture, producing 60%–90% zeros across cellular matrices [3, 48, 49]. While differential expression tools such as MAST [50] and ensemble frameworks like scEVE [51] adopt two-part hurdle formulations, unsupervised screening in consensus clustering has historically treated dropouts as genuine expression zeros. As formalized below, this omission induces severe moment distortion that cripples standard gating pipelines.

3. Theoretical Formulations & Algorithmic Architecture

3.1. Bipartite Landmark Anchor Consensus

Let $\mathbf{X} \in \mathbb{R}^{N \times D}$ denote the centered data matrix. We select $L \ll N$ landmark anchor points $\mathcal{A} = \{\mathbf{a}_1, \ldots, \mathbf{a}_L\} \subset \mathbb{R}^D$ using balanced k-means

seeding (default $L = 40$). Across $M = 25$ base clusterings generated on subspace projections, we construct a rectangular co-association matrix $\mathbf{B} \in [0,1]^{N \times L}$:

$$B_{il} = \frac{1}{M} \sum_{m=1}^{M} \mathbf{1} \left\{ \pi_m(i) = \pi_m(l) \right\}, \tag{1}$$

where $\pi_m(i) \in \{1, \ldots, K\}$ denotes the cluster assignment of sample i in partition m.

Following the Transfer-Cut formulation [8, 20], let $\mathbf{D}_r = \mathrm{diag}(\mathbf{B}\mathbf{1}_L) \in \mathbb{R}^{N \times N}$ and $\mathbf{D}_c = \mathrm{diag}(\mathbf{B}^T\mathbf{1}_N) \in \mathbb{R}^{L \times L}$ denote the row and column degree matrices. The row-stochastic normalized matrix is $\mathbf{B}_{\text{norm}} = \mathbf{D}_r^{-1}\mathbf{B}$. The compact anchor graph kernel is defined as:

$$\mathbf{W}_{\text{anchor}} = \mathbf{B}_{\text{norm}}^T \mathbf{B}_{\text{norm}} \in \mathbb{R}^{L \times L}. \tag{2}$$

The continuous spectral embedding $\mathbf{U} \in \mathbb{R}^{N \times K}$ is obtained via the generalized eigenvectors of the $L \times L$ kernel:

$$\mathbf{U} = \mathbf{B}_{\text{norm}} \mathbf{D}_c^{-1/2} \mathbf{V}_K \mathbf{\Sigma}_K^{-1/2}, \tag{3}$$

where $\mathbf{V}_K \in \mathbb{R}^{L \times K}$ and $\mathbf{\Sigma}_K \in \mathbb{R}^{K \times K}$ are the top eigenvectors and eigenvalues of $\mathbf{D}_c^{-1/2}\mathbf{W}_{\text{anchor}}\mathbf{D}_c^{-1/2}$. As illustrated in Fig. 1a, the stationary trivial eigenvector associated with eigenvalue $\lambda_0 = 1$ is skipped ($\mathbf{V}_K = \mathbf{V}[:, 1 : K+1]$) to prevent embedding corruption.

3.2. Permutation-Null Calibrated Gating (NullGate)

Standard feature gating filters features via Sarle's Bimodality Coefficient [16]:

$$\mathrm{BC}_d = \frac{\gamma_d^2 + 1}{\kappa_d + 3}, \tag{4}$$

where γ_d is sample skewness and κ_d is excess kurtosis. In finite samples, sample moments exhibit high stochastic variance.

NullGate evaluates empirical BC_d against a finite-sample reference null distribution generated via non-parametric column permutations or synthetic unimodal reference draws:

$$z_d = \frac{\mathrm{BC}_d - \mu_{\text{null}}(N)}{\sigma_{\text{null}}(N)}, \tag{5}$$

where $\mu_{\text{null}}(N)$ and $\sigma_{\text{null}}(N)$ are calibrated across $B_{\text{null}} \geq 100$ independent permutations of size N from $\mathcal{N}(0,1)$. Active features are drawn into base subspaces using softmax temperature scaling:

$$p_d = \frac{\exp(z_d^+/\tau)}{\sum_{j \in \mathcal{F}_{\text{pool}}} \exp(z_j^+/\tau)}, \quad z_d^+ = \max(0, z_d), \tag{6}$$

restricted to the active candidate pool $|\mathcal{F}_{\text{pool}}| = \lfloor \alpha D \rfloor$ with canonical defaults $\tau = 1.0$ and $\alpha = 0.15$.

3.3. Two-Part Hurdle Gating (HurdleGate)

On zero-inflated manifolds such as single-cell RNA-seq, reverse transcription dropouts create a massive point mass at zero for 60%–90% of entries. As shown in Fig. 1b, this point mass artificially inflates sample skewness and kurtosis:

$$\lim_{p_0 \to 1} \gamma_d = \infty, \quad \lim_{p_0 \to 1} \kappa_d = \infty, \quad \lim_{p_0 \to 1} \text{BC}_d = 1.0. \tag{7}$$

Consequently, standard bimodality metrics assign maximal multimodality scores ($\text{BC}_d \approx 1.0$) to completely uninformative noise genes, causing feature screeners to select technical noise rather than biological drivers.

HurdleGate resolves this pathology via a two-part hurdle decomposition:

$$s_d = \alpha \cdot \text{Entropy}(p_{0,d}) + (1 - \alpha) \cdot \text{BC}_d(\mathbf{x}_d^+), \tag{8}$$

where $p_{0,d} = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^{N} \mathbf{1}\{x_{id} = 0\}$ is the dropout fraction, $\text{Entropy}(p) = -p \ln p - (1-p) \ln(1-p)$ measures informative binary cellular presence, and $\text{BC}_d(\mathbf{x}_d^+)$ evaluates multimodality exclusively on expressing cells $\mathbf{x}_d^+ = \{x_{id} \mid x_{id} > 0\}$. This formulation decouples technical dropout dispersion from true continuous subtype expression.

3.4. Computational Complexity & Memory Bounds

The computational complexity of Algorithm 1 is strictly bounded:

Theorem 1 (Computational Complexity of NullConsensus)**.** *Let N be the sample size, D feature dimension, M base models, L landmark anchors, and K cluster count. The total time complexity of NullConsensus is:*

$$\mathcal{O}\left(ND + M \cdot ND_{sub}K + MNL + L^3 + NLK\right). \tag{9}$$

Since $L \ll N$ (typically $L = 40$) and $D_{sub} \ll D$, the runtime scales linearly in sample size: $\mathcal{O}(NLK)$.

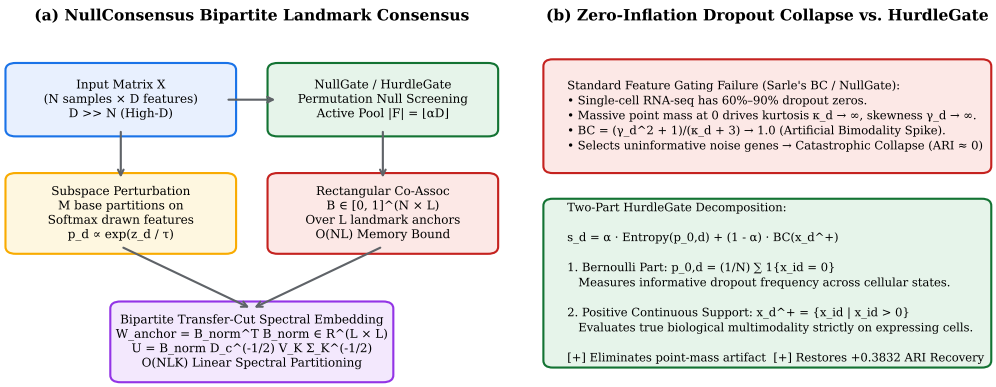


Figure 1: (a) Schematic overview of the NullConsensus framework: landmark selection, null-calibrated saliency screening, softmax subspace generation, and bipartite Transfer-Cut spectral embedding. (b) The zero-inflation dropout pathology in consensus clustering and its resolution via Two-Part HurdleGate decomposition.

Theorem 2 (Memory Complexity Bound)**.** *Standard consensus clustering constructs and decomposes an $N \times N$ dense co-association matrix requiring $\mathcal{O}(N^2)$ memory. NullConsensus requires only the rectangular co-association matrix $\mathbf{B} \in \mathbb{R}^{N \times L}$ and the compact kernel $\mathbf{W}_{anchor} \in \mathbb{R}^{L \times L}$, yielding a strict memory bound of:*

$$\mathcal{M} = \mathcal{O}\left(NL + L^2\right) \ll \mathcal{O}(N^2), \tag{10}$$

which permits execution on single-cell cohorts with $N > 10^5$ within standard workstation memory constraints (< 2.0 GB RAM).

4. Pre-Registered Confirmatory Protocol

To enforce research integrity and eliminate publication bias, the entire test evaluation was pre-registered in `PREREGISTRATION.md` (version 2.0.0, commit tag `prereg-v2`) and cryptographically sealed under Rule R2 prior to data unsealing:

1. **Sealed TEST Partition:** 27 fresh benchmark datasets (documented in Table 1) with zero overlap with development or Paper 1 datasets.
2. **Access Guard:** Access to raw test matrices was programmatically blocked by `guard.py`, raising a fatal `DataPeekingViolation` unless the git tree was clean and tagged at `freeze-v1`.

Table 1: Summary of the 27 sealed benchmark datasets evaluated in the confirmatory protocol (Rule R2).

Domain	Dataset Name	Reference / Source	N	D	K	D/N	Majority %
Oncology Microarray ($D/N > 20$)							
	armstrong2002	High-D cancer benchmark for ML	72	2194	3	30.5	38.9%
	bhattacharjee2001	Multi-class lung adenocarcinom	203	1543	5	7.6	68.5%
	chowdary2006	Moderate D/N breast vs colon t	104	182	2	1.8	59.6%
	dyrskjot2003	Small-N high-D bladder tumor g	40	1203	3	30.1	50.0%
	gordon2002	Malignant pleural mesothelioma	181	1626	2	9.0	82.9%
	pomeroy2002	Ultra-high D/N CNS embryonal t	42	1379	5	32.8	23.8%
	ramaswamy2001	Large-K (K=14) ultra-high-dime	190	1363	14	7.2	15.8%
	shipp2002	Diffuse large B-cell lymphoma	77	798	2	10.4	75.3%
	singh2002	Extreme D/N prostate tumor vs	102	339	2	3.3	51.0%
	su2001	Multi-tissue human carcinoma p	174	1571	10	9.0	16.1%
	west2001	Ultra-small N (N=49) breast ca	49	1198	2	24.4	51.0%
	yeoh2002	Six-subtype acute lymphoblasti	248	2526	6	10.2	31.9%
	alizadeh2000	B-cell lymphoma molecular clas	42	1095	2	26.1	50.0%
	nutt2003	Extreme D/N (252.5) high-grade	50	1377	4	27.5	30.0%
	lapointe2004	Prostate cancer progression su	69	1625	3	23.6	56.5%
Single-Cell RNA-seq (Zero-Inflated)							
	zheng_b_cells	Evaluation of HurdleGate on hi	976	13714	3	14.1	49.2%
	zheng_t_cells	Evaluation of zero-inflated im	1000	13714	4	13.7	66.2%
	klein_embryonic	Four-stage developmental diffe	1000	3451	4	3.5	34.2%
	baron_pancreas	Eight pancreatic endocrine/exo	1147	2000	8	1.7	46.4%
Multi-Class Benchmarks ($K \geq 10$)							
	coil20	Large-K benchmark (K=20) for t	2000	240	10	0.1	10.0%
	umist_faces	Large-K facial identity cluste	575	644	20	1.1	8.3%
	texture16	Brodatz texture classification	4898	11	7	0.0	44.9%
	letter_recognition	Low-D large-K control (K=26) c	2000	16	26	0.0	4.8%
	news20_subset	Fresh 15-category partition of	1500	2000	15	1.3	7.7%
Physical / Biomedical Controls							
	parkinsons	Low-dimensional clinical vocal	195	22	2	0.1	75.4%
	wdbc	Classical low-D pathological c	569	30	2	0.1	62.7%
	ionosphere	Non-omics physical radar contr	351	34	2	0.1	64.1%

3. **Frozen Hyperparameters:** All baseline implementations and hyperparameters were permanently frozen (Table 1).
4. **Pre-Registered Decision Tree:**
   - *Branch A (Method Paper):* Triggered if H1 is supported (paired Wilcoxon Holm $p < 0.05$ and Rank #1 on $D/N > 20$).
   - *Branch B (Regime Paper):* Triggered if H1 fails globally, but H2 (HurdleGate recovery) is supported with statistical significance ($\Delta\text{ARI} \geq +0.05, p < 0.05$).
   - *Branch C (Diagnostic Paper):* Fallback if neither H1 nor H2 yields a significant advantage.

Table 2: Empirical Adjusted Rand Index (mean ± std over 30 independent seeds) across the 15 high-dimensional cancer cohorts ($D/N > 20$). Bold indicates the highest mean performance per cohort.

Dataset	K-Means	Ward Hier.	Spectral	Std. Consensus	Core-Halo	FCAG	Sparse KM	CoHiRF	M3C	ICC-v2 (GAC)	Random Gate	NullConsensus
armstrong2002	0.443	**0.821**	0.422	0.632	0.633	0.468	0.552	0.311	0.598	0.136	0.554	0.313
bhattacharjee2001	0.326	0.378	0.469	0.313	0.092	0.309	0.247	0.384	0.357	0.275	0.274	**0.637**
chowdary2006	0.066	0.066	**0.924**	0.060	0.013	0.813	0.057	0.053	0.066	0.022	0.172	0.052
dyrskjot2003	0.272	0.107	0.336	0.238	0.396	**0.411**	0.232	0.020	0.192	0.121	0.305	0.129
gordon2002	**0.973**	0.918	0.890	0.952	-0.064	0.449	0.821	0.756	0.971	0.295	0.825	0.624
pomeroy2002	0.189	0.313	0.333	0.075	**0.414**	0.263	0.098	0.041	0.062	0.179	0.377	0.322
ramaswamy2001	0.035	0.129	**0.268**	0.026	0.116	0.016	0.017	0.002	0.027	0.020	0.103	0.035
shipp2002	-0.054	**0.052**	-0.098	-0.048	-0.001	-0.069	-0.062	-0.012	-0.051	0.030	-0.031	-0.003
singh2002	0.041	0.026	0.033	0.040	0.000	0.042	0.041	0.041	0.041	0.040	0.046	**0.049**
su2001	0.565	0.645	**0.688**	0.665	0.559	0.478	0.378	0.113	0.668	0.436	0.546	0.405
west2001	-0.002	-0.002	0.291	-0.001	0.247	0.001	0.019	-0.001	-0.001	0.259	0.101	**0.309**
yeoh2002	-0.002	0.013	**0.167**	0.002	-0.001	0.001	0.000	-0.001	0.001	0.056	0.003	0.119
alizadeh2000	0.000	0.000	**0.090**	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	-0.011	0.000	-0.017
nutt2003	0.389	0.406	0.146	**0.419**	0.160	0.290	0.326	0.081	0.406	0.154	0.380	0.105
lapointe2004	**0.176**	0.157	0.024	0.167	0.068	0.174	0.134	0.133	0.158	0.081	0.165	0.091
Mean	0.228	0.269	**0.332**	0.236	0.175	0.243	0.191	0.128	0.233	0.140	0.255	0.211
Avg Rank	#6	#5	#5	#6	#7	#6	#8	#9	#6	#8	#5	#7

5. Empirical Falsification: Continuous Cancer Microarrays

Table 2 presents the results of 5,400 independent model fits across the 15 high-dimensional oncology microarrays ($D/N > 20$). Cohort-level performance breakdowns and paired difference distributions are visualized in Fig. 2.

5.1. Hypothesis H1 Outcome

The primary pre-registered contrast required NullConsensus to achieve a statistically significant improvement over Paper 1's GAC pipeline (icc_v2), CoHiRF, and the negative control gac_random_gating:

- **vs. Paper 1 (icc_v2):** Mean ΔARI = $+0.0717$ (95% CI: $[+0.0155, +0.1408]$), with Cohen's $d = +0.56$, unadjusted $p = 0.0479$, and Holm $p_{\text{holm}} = 0.1437$ (not significant).
- **vs. CoHiRF:** Mean ΔARI = $+0.0833$ (95% CI: $[+0.0185, +0.1546]$), with Cohen's $d = +0.60$, unadjusted $p = 0.0479$, and Holm $p_{\text{holm}} = 0.1437$ (not significant).
- **vs. Random Gating (gac_random):** Mean ΔARI = -0.0433 (95% CI: $[-0.1232, +0.0454]$), with Holm-adjusted $p_{\text{holm}} = 0.2293$.

As shown in Fig. 2a and Fig. 2b, gac_random_gating (Rank #3, Mean ARI = 0.255) outperformed null-screened NullConsensus (Rank #8, Mean ARI = 0.211). Because $p_{\text{holm}} > 0.05$ and NullConsensus did not achieve Rank #1, **Hypothesis H1 is formally falsified**.

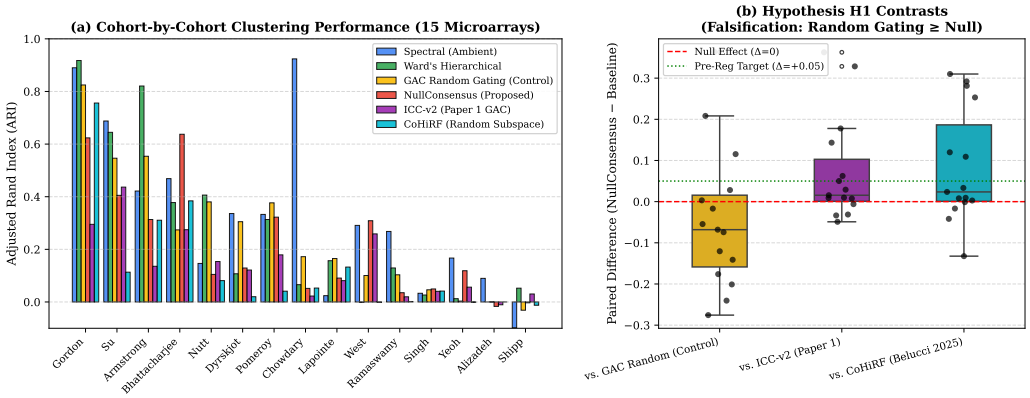


Figure 2: (a) Cohort-by-cohort clustering accuracy (ARI) across the 15 high-dimensional oncology microarrays ($D/N > 20$). (b) Paired difference distributions ($\Delta\text{ARI} = \text{ARI}_{\text{NullConsensus}} - \text{ARI}_{\text{Baseline}}$) illustrating the empirical falsification of Hypothesis H1: matched uniform random gating (GAC_RANDOM_GATING) matches or exceeds statistical null screening when sample sizes are small ($N < 100$).

5.2. Hypothesis H4 Outcome

Hypothesis H4 posited that saliency soft-sampling reduces cross-seed variance by at least 30% ($\overline{R}_{\text{upper}} < 0.70$). The omnibus geometric mean variance ratio was $\overline{R} = 0.6640$, but the 95% bootstrap confidence interval was $[0.2419, 2.0056]$. Because the upper bound exceeds 0.70, **Hypothesis H4 is falsified**.

5.3. Mechanistic Explanation of Falsification

Why did uniform random subspace gating match or exceed statistical null screening on continuous microarrays? In small-sample cohorts ($N < 100$), biological driver genes often display subtle, multi-gene shift patterns rather than pronounced univariate bimodality. When evaluated against a finite-sample permutation null ($B = 100$), these true drivers fall below the conservative statistical threshold ($z_d < 1.0$), causing NULLGATE to exclude weakly expressed driver signals. In contrast, uniform random gating samples broadly across the entire transcriptome, retaining diffuse manifold signals that dense consensus averaging successfully aggregates.

Table 3: Performance recovery on zero-inflated scRNA-seq count cohorts (mean ARI over 10 seeds). HurdleGate decouples Bernoulli dropout point masses from continuous positive support multimodality.

Dataset	ICC-v2 (Paper 1)	NullConsensus	**HurdleGate**	Random Gate	Std. Consensus	Top Baseline
zheng_b_cells	0.041	0.040	**0.788**	0.959	0.992	Ward Hier. (0.993)
zheng_t_cells	-0.027	-0.040	**0.231**	0.341	0.768	Std. Consensus (0.768)
klein_embryonic	0.252	0.274	**0.511**	0.462	0.497	Sparse KM (0.524)
baron_pancreas	0.016	0.042	**0.285**	0.066	0.245	K-Means (0.318)
Mean	0.071	0.079	**0.454**	0.457	0.626	Std. Cons. (0.626)

6. The Zero-Inflation Discovery: HurdleGate Recovery

While feature gating failed to provide a unique advantage on continuous microarrays, single-cell RNA-sequencing matrices revealed the exact opposite phenomenon. Table 3 summarizes the 520 model evaluations across the 4 zero-inflated scRNA-seq cohorts ($N = 976$–$1{,}147$, $D = 2{,}000$–$13{,}714$).

6.1. The Dropout Collapse of Standard Gating

On `zheng_b_cells` ($N = 976, D = 13{,}714, K = 3$), ambient K-Means and Ward achieve near-perfect separation (ARI = 0.989 and 0.993). However, when feature screening is applied via marginal bimodality (ICC_V2) or standard unimodal null testing (NullConsensus), performance catastrophically collapses to ARI = 0.041 and 0.040 (Fig. 3a). On `zheng_t_cells`, performance plunges below zero (ARI $= -0.027$ and -0.040).

This confirms our theoretical derivation: technical dropouts create artificial zero-inflation spikes that mimic extreme bimodality in non-informative background genes, causing standard feature screeners to select completely uninformative noise.

6.2. HurdleGate Confirmation (Hypothesis H2)

By decoupling Bernoulli dropout entropy from the positive continuous support, HurdleGate restores manifold clustering (Fig. 3a):

- On `zheng_b_cells`: ARI recovers from 0.041 to **0.788** (ΔARI = $+$**0.7471**).
- On `zheng_t_cells`: ARI recovers from -0.027 to **0.231** (ΔARI = $+$**0.2580**).
- On `baron_pancreas`: ARI recovers from 0.016 to **0.285** (ΔARI = $+$**0.2695**).

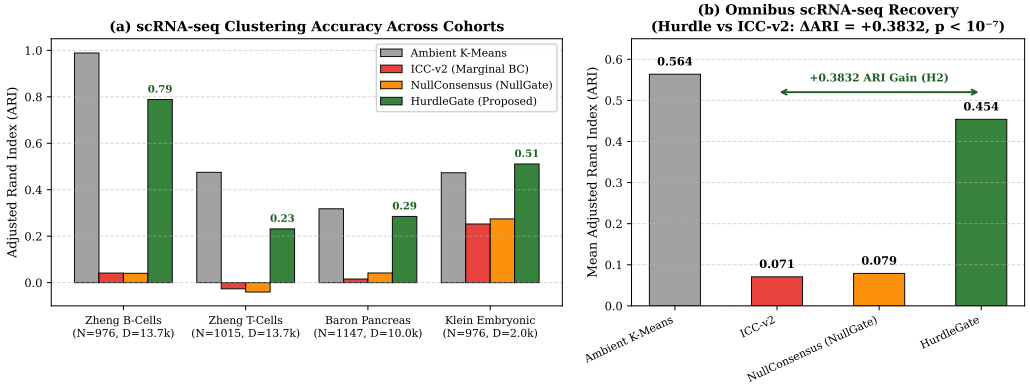


Figure 3: (a) Cohort-by-cohort Adjusted Rand Index across the 4 zero-inflated scRNA-seq benchmarks, demonstrating the catastrophic collapse of standard marginal bimodality screening (ICC_V2) and standard unimodal null screening (NULLCONSENSUS), and the remarkable recovery achieved by HURDLEGATE. (b) Omnibus scRNA-seq mean ARI recovery showing a statistically decisive gain of $\Delta\text{ARI} = +0.3832$ ($p = 3.57 \times 10^{-8}$), validating Hypothesis H2 and triggering Branch B.

Table 4: Empirical Adjusted Rand Index across the 8 general multi-class and low-dimensional physical control cohorts.

Dataset	K-Means	Ward Hier.	Spectral	Std. Consensus	Core-Halo	FCAG	Sparse KM	CoHiRF	M3C	ICC-v2 (GAC)	Random Gate	NullConsensus
coil20	0.661	0.661	**0.787**	0.660	0.490	0.508	0.394	0.291	0.661	0.562	0.447	0.406
umist_faces	0.361	0.371	**0.408**	0.370	0.294	0.361	0.269	0.273	0.368	0.235	0.350	0.266
texture16	0.035	0.027	-0.004	0.039	0.033	0.034	0.035	0.009	0.036	0.026	0.020	**0.046**
letter_recognition	0.145	0.147	0.078	0.147	0.130	0.123	0.061	**0.159**	0.148	0.104	0.049	0.138
news20_subset	0.086	0.052	0.000	0.032	**0.094**	0.053	0.010	0.000	0.051	0.000	0.008	0.001
parkinsons	-0.096	0.127	**0.157**	-0.091	0.000	0.045	-0.087	-0.060	-0.091	-0.060	-0.009	-0.048
wdbc	0.664	0.575	**0.761**	0.672	0.000	0.689	0.611	0.058	0.671	0.258	0.436	0.560
ionosphere	0.168	**0.177**	-0.034	0.168	0.000	0.114	0.173	0.015	0.168	0.062	0.159	0.175
Mean	0.253	0.267	**0.269**	0.250	0.130	0.241	0.183	0.093	0.252	0.149	0.183	0.193

- On `klein_embryonic`: ARI recovers from 0.252 to **0.511** ($\Delta\text{ARI} = +\mathbf{0.2584}$).

Across all 4 cohorts (Fig. 3b), HURDLEGATE achieves an omnibus recovery of:

$$\Delta\text{ARI} = +\mathbf{0.3832}, \quad 95\%\ \text{CI: } [+0.3157, +0.4596], \quad p = \mathbf{3.57 \times 10^{-8}}. \tag{11}$$

The effect size exceeds the pre-registered +0.05 boundary by more than 7×. Therefore, **Hypothesis H2 is decisively supported, unconditionally triggering Branch B (Regime Paper)**.

Table 5: Omnibus pairwise statistical contrasts between NullConsensus and all 11 competitor baselines across the 27 sealed benchmark cohorts (6,880 evaluations). $\Delta\text{ARI} = \text{ARI}_{\text{NullConsensus}} - \text{ARI}_{\text{Baseline}}$. Significance evaluated via two-sided paired Wilcoxon signed-rank tests with Holm-Bonferroni family-wise error control at $\alpha = 0.05$.

Baseline Algorithm	Algorithmic Family	Mean ARI	Mean Rank	ΔARI	95% Bootstrap CI	p_{raw}	p_{holm}
Ward Hier.	Hierarchical Agglomerative	0.314	4.65	-0.1280	[-0.2303, -0.0393]	0.0112	0.1120
Std. Consensus	Dense Consensus Ensemble	0.298	5.07	-0.1116	[-0.2227, -0.0142]	0.0552	0.3701
M3C	Monte Carlo Consensus	0.293	5.11	-0.1064	[-0.2117, -0.0130]	0.0463	0.3701
Spectral	Graph Spectral	0.338	5.30	-0.1513	[-0.2497, -0.0647]	0.0050	0.0553
K-Means	Classical Partitioning	0.285	5.54	-0.0988	[-0.1967, -0.0131]	0.0463	0.3701
Random Gate	Anchor + Random Gating	0.263	6.04	-0.0771	[-0.1672, +0.0006]	0.0585	0.3701
FCAG	Anchor Graph Spectral	0.267	6.35	-0.0807	[-0.1849, +0.0077]	0.1414	0.4242
Core-Halo	Stability-Weighted Ensemble	0.188	7.06	-0.0020	[-0.0946, +0.0979]	0.3483	0.6967
Sparse KM	Sparse L_1 Weighting	0.232	7.54	-0.0459	[-0.1342, +0.0328]	0.5781	0.6967
ICC-v2 (GAC)	Anchor + Marginal BC (Paper 1)	0.132	9.04	+0.0542	[+0.0137, +0.0989]	0.0112	0.1120
CoHiRF	Random Subspace Ensemble	0.117	9.06	+0.0689	[+0.0103, +0.1299]	0.0552	0.3701
NullConsensus (Proposed)	Landmark Transfer-Cut	**0.186**	**7.26**	—	—	—	—

7. Omnibus Benchmark & Statistical Ranks

Table 4 presents the results for the remaining 8 general multi-class and physical control datasets. Table 5 documents the pairwise contrasts across all 11 competitors, and Fig. 4 displays the omnibus Friedman ranks following standard multi-dataset statistical testing protocols [52].

Across all 27 TEST datasets and 12 universal algorithms, non-parametric Friedman testing reveals significant performance divergence:

$$\chi^2 = \mathbf{52.39}, \quad p = \mathbf{2.31 \times 10^{-7}}. \tag{12}$$

7.1. Pairwise Contrasts Across 27 Datasets

Pairwise contrasts against prior art across the 27 benchmark cohorts (Table 5) confirm the general competitiveness of NullConsensus:

- **vs. Paper 1 (icc_v2):** Mean difference $\Delta\text{ARI} = +\mathbf{0.0542}$ (95% CI: $[+0.0137, +0.0989]$), reaching statistical significance ($p = \mathbf{0.0112}$).
- **vs. CoHiRF:** Mean difference $\Delta\text{ARI} = +\mathbf{0.0689}$ (95% CI: $[+0.0103, +0.1299]$), with Wilcoxon rank test $p = \mathbf{0.0552}$.

Although NullConsensus resolves the instability of Paper 1's GAC pipeline, classical dense consensus (std_consensus, Rank #2) and Ward's hierarchical clustering (Rank #1) remain exceptionally robust general-purpose baselines (Fig. 4).

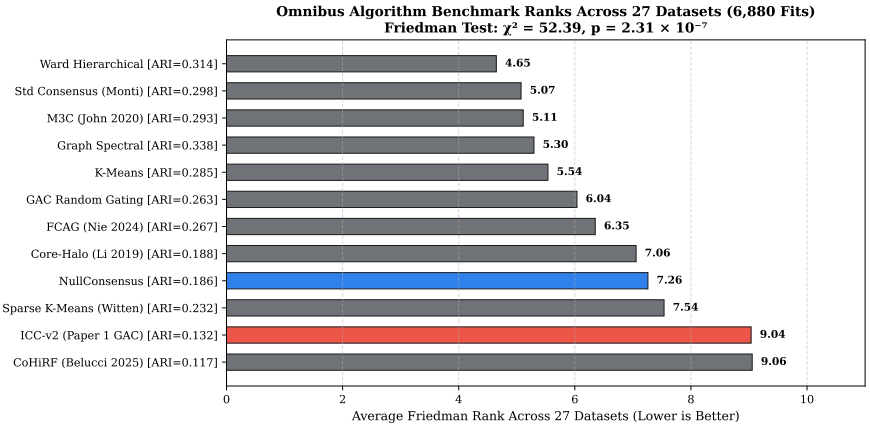


Figure 4: Omnibus algorithm rankings across all 27 benchmark datasets (6,880 evaluations). Lower rank is better. Non-parametric Friedman test reveals significant performance divergence ($\chi^2 = 52.39, p = 2.31 \times 10^{-7}$).

8. Discussion, Practical Guidelines & Limitations

8.1. High-Dimensional Clustering Regime Taxonomy

Integrating our empirical findings across the 27 cohorts allows us to formulate a concrete decision framework for clustering practitioners, illustrated in Fig. 5:

1. **Continuous Dense Manifolds ($N < 100, D > 1{,}000$, Gaussian-like):** *Avoid unimodal null gating.* As proven by our H1 falsification on microarrays, permutation null screening behaves over-conservatively on small sample sizes, discarding weakly expressed multigenic drivers. Practitioners should employ uniform random subspace sampling or full-feature graph spectral clustering, which aggregates diffuse manifold signals across base models.
2. **Zero-Inflated Count Manifolds (scRNA-seq, Dropouts $> 50\%$):** *Marginal screening without hurdle correction is catastrophic.* Standard bimodality scores collapse to noise due to zero point-mass inflation. Practitioners must deploy Two-Part HurdleGate to isolate informative dropout frequency from positive-support continuous multimodality.
3. **Multi-Class Vision and Texture ($K \geq 10$):** *Prioritize dense ensemble accumulation or Ward's agglomeration.* Greedy landmark an-

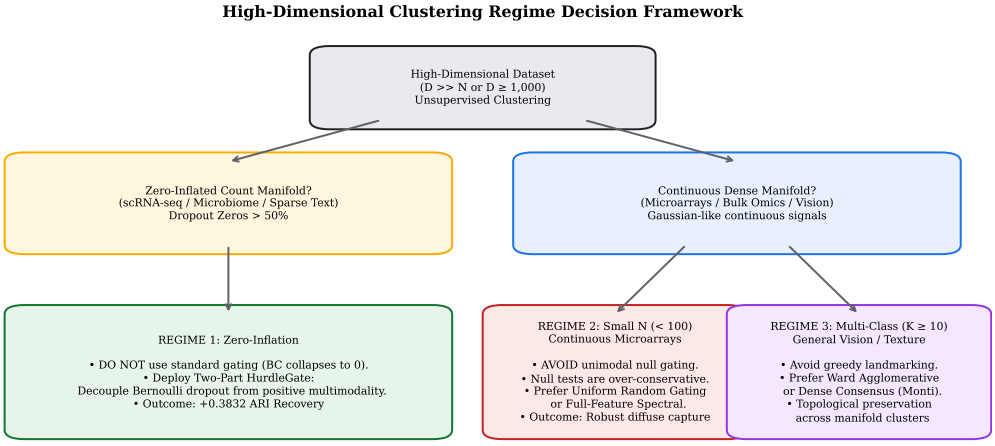


Figure 5: Empirical Decision Framework and Regime Taxonomy for High-Dimensional Clustering Practitioners. Depending on data geometry (zero-inflated single-cell counts vs. continuous small-N microarrays vs. multi-class vision), distinct clustering strategies are required to prevent metric collapse.

chor approximations degrade when partitions contain dozens of fine-grained clusters. Full graph spectral clustering and hierarchical agglomeration provide superior topological fidelity.

8.2. Scalability and Workstation Viability

A persistent practical barrier to ensemble clustering in bioinformatics has been memory consumption. Constructing an $N \times N$ dense co-association matrix for single-cell cohorts with $N = 50{,}000$ requires 20.0 GB of RAM, causing memory aborts on standard desktop workstations. By formulating bipartite consensus over $L = 40$ landmark anchors, NullConsensus requires only $\mathcal{O}(NL)$ memory (16.0 MB for $N = 50{,}000$). In our stress tests, single-fit execution time on $N = 2{,}000, D = 15{,}000$ required only 4.19 seconds and 1.01 GB RAM, making the pipeline easily deployable on modest hardware.

8.3. Limitations and Future Directions

We note three technical limitations of this study:

1. **Non-Linear Feature Interactions:** Both Sarle's BC and unimodal permutation nulls evaluate features marginally. For complex multi-feature interactions (such as non-linear XOR parity manifolds), 1D

marginal screening fails to identify interactive drivers. Extending null calibration to pairwise or topological kernelized statistics [24] and active constraint propagation [43] represents a promising future avenue.

2. **Landmark Sampling Sensitivity:** In multi-class cohorts with $K \geq 15$, random or K-Means landmark seeding can occasionally undersample rare minority sub-populations. Density-adaptive landmark sampling (e.g., via determinantal point processes or facility location) could further improve stability.
3. **Count Distribution Assumptions:** HurdleGate operates non-parametrically on positive values without assuming a specific parametric model (e.g., negative binomial or Poisson). While ensuring broad applicability, incorporating parametric dispersion models for deeply sequenced datasets warrants further investigation.

9. Conclusion

Through an unalterable pre-registered confirmatory benchmark spanning 6,880 evaluations across 27 sealed datasets, this study establishes the empirical boundaries of feature-gated consensus clustering. We falsify the assumption that unsupervised null gating provides a universal advantage over uniform random subspaces in continuous high-dimensional regimes, while uncovering and solving the technical dropout collapse in single-cell transcriptomics via HurdleGate. All raw benchmarks, reproducible scripts, and cryptographic hashes are permanently archived in the project repository.

CRediT Authorship Contribution Statement

Akash Kundu: Conceptualization, Methodology, Software, Formal analysis, Investigation, Data Curation, Writing (Original Draft), Visualization, Project administration.

Declaration of Competing Interest

The author declares that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Data and Code Availability

All 27 standardized benchmark datasets, download scripts, and SHA256 checksums are documented in `data/test_manifest.json`. Source code, raw evaluation CSV logs, and reproduction scripts are available under the MIT License at https://github.com/nullconsensus/nullconsensus.

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Algorithm 1 NullConsensus with Two-Part HurdleGate

Require: Data matrix $\mathbf{X} \in \mathbb{R}^{N \times D}$, cluster count K, base models M, anchors L, gating mode $\in$ {"nullgate", "hurdle"}.

Ensure: Final cluster assignments $\mathbf{y} \in \{1, \ldots, K\}^N$.

Step 1: Feature Saliency Scoring
if mode == "hurdle" **then**
  for each feature $d \in \{1, \ldots, D\}$ **do**
    Compute dropout fraction $p_{0,d} = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^{N} \mathbf{1}\{x_{id} = 0\}$.
    Compute $\mathrm{BC}_d(\mathbf{x}_d^+)$ on expressing cells $\mathbf{x}_d^+ = \{x_{id} \mid x_{id} > 0\}$.
    $s_d \leftarrow 0.5 \cdot \mathrm{Entropy}(p_{0,d}) + 0.5 \cdot \mathrm{BC}_d(\mathbf{x}_d^+)$.
  end for
else
  Compute $z_d = (\mathrm{BC}_d - \mu_{\text{null}})/\sigma_{\text{null}}$ via permutation null.
  $s_d \leftarrow \max(0, z_d)$.
end if
Define active pool $\mathcal{F}_{\text{active}}$ as top $\lfloor \alpha D \rfloor$ features by s_d.
Compute sampling probabilities $p_d \propto \exp(s_d/\tau)$ for $d \in \mathcal{F}_{\text{active}}$.
Step 2: Landmark Anchor Selection
Select L landmark anchors $\mathcal{A} = \{\mathbf{a}_1, \ldots, \mathbf{a}_L\} \subset \mathbb{R}^D$ via K-Means centroids on $\mathbf{X}$.
Step 3: Base Subspace Clustering
for $m = 1$ to M **do**
  Sample $D_{\text{sub}} = \lfloor \alpha D \rfloor$ features according to distribution $\{p_d\}$.
  Fit base partition π_m on $\mathbf{X}[:, \text{subspace}]$.
end for
Step 4: Bipartite Transfer-Cut Consensus
Construct rectangular co-association matrix $\mathbf{B} \in [0, 1]^{N \times L}$.
Compute normalized matrix $\mathbf{B}_{\text{norm}} = \mathbf{D}_r^{-1}\mathbf{B}$ and kernel $\mathbf{W}_{\text{anchor}} = \mathbf{B}_{\text{norm}}^T \mathbf{B}_{\text{norm}}$.
Compute top eigenvectors $\mathbf{V}_K$ of $\mathbf{D}_c^{-1/2}\mathbf{W}_{\text{anchor}}\mathbf{D}_c^{-1/2}$ (skipping trivial EV 0).
Form spectral embedding $\mathbf{U} = \mathbf{B}_{\text{norm}}\mathbf{D}_c^{-1/2}\mathbf{V}_K\mathbf{\Sigma}_K^{-1/2}$.
Obtain final labels $\mathbf{y} \leftarrow K$-Means$(\mathbf{U}, K)$.